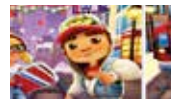




20GB on Skydrive

Microsoft offers an extra 20GB of cloud storage on SkyDrive for one year for all Windows Phone users for a limited time <http://dgit.in/1gRhsB1>



Subway Surfers WP8

Subway Surfers arrives on WP8 platform for devices with 1GB of RAM <http://dgit.in/IX7vDB>



This month we highlight some aspiring tech writers and their spirited attempt to get published in the magazine. Let's have more!

Readers' write-ups



Palash

What went wrong with AMD laptops!?

This one comes from an avid AMD supporter cum fan, but not a techno racist! I remember the time when AMD used to

advertise their multitasking capabilities on TV via a clunky 'Office boss' commercial! But at that time, I didn't even know what AMD was. All I could grasp from that commercial was, 'AMD is something related to doing multiple things at once!' Well, time flies. Now after all these years reading and exploring about tech stuff and owning this processor brand for over 5 years I've realised what AMD is!

Mobility has become a priority these days, the thought of writing this article came to my mind when one fine day a friend of mine was in the market looking for a performance machine on a restricted budget! So we both went hunting for an AMD laptop. Some small dealers, to our surprise didn't even know that AMD makes mobile processors. Selling them was out of question! Second option, some well known retail chains. It was pleasing to see 2 or 3 AMD based laptops trying lure buyers in this Intel dominated territory. But they were mostly dual core and low end models with a low end IGPU. Last option - shop online. And that was it, we could find some real good AMD configuration on our beloved Flipkart.

After using the machine for few weeks, we were quite surprised to see how "beastie" it's performance was. We grabbed a quad core A10 clocked at 2.3Ghz(3.2Ghz turbo) paired with AMD's HD 7670M in Cross-FireX with the iGPU HD7660, for less than ₹38K. Sounds like a gaming monsters, doesn't it?! Well, most of the recent titles were running lag free at medium to

high settings at native resolution. Which is very impressive for a sub ₹40K laptop. Now, here comes the question, "If these laptops are so powerful and relatively cheap, then why aren't they selling like hot cakes!?" My views on this question are presented below-

The big "Over Heating" myth:

Okay, some initial AMD 'Athlons' had overheating issues, but that was back in the 2003-2005 era. This is 2013, and some wise Youtubers have proved with their thermal guns, that AMD runs cooler than Intel. But, this myth or hoax has significantly affected sales here in India. No matter whom you ask, either they don't know about AMD or they simply talk about Overheating and after sales Service.

Advertising.

Since that TV commercial which I saw in my childhood, I haven't come across even a single Commercial from this 2nd largest Processor maker! Strange, but true. We Indians are fond of Commercials which boasts of features that these devices claim to have!

Demoralisation by the dealers.

This, at present could be the prime reason for low sales. Dealers, they simply ignore you when try to step out of Intel territory to buy something that is not overpriced as hell and makes sense overall. In our experience, 9 out of 10 dealers told us not to buy AMD. Reason - "No just don't". We were ordered not to buy it for no reason! Well played 'commission'! Yes, It was in the media a few years ago, that the competitor was found to be paying retailers a little extra to as compared to the commission given to dealers for selling AMD products.

Synthetic benchmarks, the truth behind them.

So, we found many people talking about AMD's not-so-impressive(according to them) performance. As almost none of them had actually used an AMD machine, their claims were clearly based on Synthetic benchmarks. Benchmarks, (those darned software) which calculates and rates your hardware according to some parameters. So, they're just software, optimization matters. Example, In Digit's recent Nexus 5 benchmarking review, Antutu gave it 25262 points, where as Phones running even less powerful hardware got above 30000 points. What now!?! A Layman would badge the Nexus as mediocre device without even having a look at it's real world performance! Real World performance, yes this is the place where AMD shines and clearly marches ahead of its competition! We were pleased to multitask on our AMD laptop where a ₹50K, Intel i5 powered pseudo 'BEAST' gave up and literally hung itself.

OEMs Showing less interest.

Very few manufacturers have exposed our market with Top end AMD models(The A10's A8's). Only HP, Lenovo and Samsung are shipping high-end AMD powered laptops to India. The model we tested was HP g6 2313Ax. As already said, performance was surprising for the price we paid for it!

Bottom line, AMD needs to wake up, show more interest towards growing markets like ours. Advertise their product dynamically. They create some of the best processors, enthusiasts still remember the old warhorses, Phenom X4 and Athlon II. But sadly never got the market share that they truly deserved for the mean beasts that they happened to be.